



BEFORE

Lincoln was the first president to be elected on a purely sectional basis with almost exclusively Northern votes.

FREE-SOIL PLATFORM

Not only did Lincoln win without any Southern electoral college votes (see [Abraham Lincoln](#)), but he also ran on an **explicitly anti-slavery platform**, pledging to prevent further territorial expansion of slavery. Republicans **recognized the constitutional protection of slavery** in states where it already existed, and focused on **preventing the expansion of slavery** in territories that had not yet attained statehood.

PREVIOUS ATTEMPTS AT SECESSION

South Carolina had seriously contemplated secession during the [Nullification Crisis of 1833](#), but retreated due to a lack of support from other Southern states. Sectional tensions flared again in relation to slavery in **the territories captured in the** [War with Mexico](#), but calmed after the passage of the [Compromise of 1850](#).

Shortly after Abraham Lincoln's election as president, the entire lower South (South Carolina, Mississippi, Florida, Alabama, Georgia, Louisiana, and Texas) seceded from the Union through the device of state conventions. On the principle that each state was a sovereign entity in and of itself, they voted to form a new nation called the "Confederate States of America." Furthermore, Alexander Stephens, vice president of the new nation, declared of its government that "its foundations are laid, its cornerstone rests, upon the great truth that the negro is not equal to the white man; that slavery, subordination to the superior race, is his natural and moral condition."